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Becoming part of the conspiracy theory: far-right framings of museums and public libraries on Swedish YouTube

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Abstract

Purpose – The study has a twofold purpose to gain new insights into how contemporary antagonistic conflicts over culture unfold and the roles of libraries and museums therein and to contribute to a deeper understanding of the transnational dynamics of far-right rhetoric, and how it effects society's democratic infrastructure, of which libraries and museums form part.

Design/methodology/approach – The study adopts a nexus approach that combines data-driven methods with qualitative-mediated narrative analysis. YouTube was selected as the empirical site due to its central role in contemporary information infrastructures. The dataset comprises 1,312 transcribed videos from three Swedish far-right YouTube channels collected via the YouTube API. Eight highly viewed videos focusing on libraries and museums were selected for qualitative analysis, complemented by topic modelling of the full corpus.

Findings – In the analysed material, museums and libraries are rhetorically used to foster anxieties characteristic of far-right populism: the imagined threat of migrants displacing the native population and undermining welfare provisions, fears of cultural decline, the erosion of national traditions and a presumed inability of the state to serve the people's interest. By exploiting the enablements of YouTube and drawing on conspiratorial narratives of corrupt elites, libraries and museums are rhetorically recast as tools, victims or at times even as agents of indoctrination.

Originality/value – The study contributes to a deeper understanding of how museums and libraries are appropriated in far-right media ecosystems. It also provides new knowledge on how far-right rhetoric contests and acts against democratic infrastructures by exploiting elite distrust and calling the legitimacy of established institutions into question.

Keywords Public libraries, Museums, Culture wars, Far-right, Conspiracy theories

Paper type Research article

Introduction

In recent years, public libraries and museums have increasingly become contested institutions in the ongoing culture wars (e.g. Chrastka, 2025; Jaeger, 2025; Hanell *et al.*, 2025a), a global ideological conflict marked by deepening polarization over social values, identity politics and the notion of culture. Generally regarded as spaces dedicated to education and inclusion (e.g. Audunson *et al.*, 2020; Kranich, 2020), museums and libraries are now drawn into controversies over programming related to LGBTQI + rights, multiculturalism, history and memory. In Sweden, the country in focus of this study, politicians and segments of the public have called for the cancellation of events and exhibitions perceived as ideologically charged (Engström *et al.*, 2024). At the same time, librarians and museum professionals report self-censorship driven by threats of online harassment and on-site confrontation from far-right actors (Hanell *et al.*, 2025b; Engman, 2025). This invokes questions about the logics through

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which cultural institutions are targeted, the ways in which they are situated within contemporary conflicts over the role of culture in society and the broader consequences of this positioning.

This article addresses these questions by exploring how museums and libraries are symbolically and rhetorically mobilized in online far-right culture wars discourse. Specifically, the study investigates how public libraries and museums are incorporated into far-right conspiracy narratives and ideological myths, with a particular focus on YouTube as an important site of this ideological production and dissemination. Conspiracy theories in this context function as a form of theodicy, offering simplified, emotionally resonant explanations for perceived societal injustices (cf. Astapova *et al.*, 2021). Hence, these narratives not only target the institutions themselves but also frame them as representatives of broader social transformations, perceived as "evil" and threatening to societal cohesion and national identity. In the culture wars context, what is considered "corrupt", or "evil" is increasingly contested and often defined within polarized and digital-first publics (cf. Törnberg and Törnberg, 2024). YouTube thus becomes a stage where boundaries are redrawn and previous agreements over the role of culture in society are challenged.

Against this backdrop, the article sets out with a twofold purpose. By exploring how libraries and museums are featured in Swedish far-right YouTube content, we seek to gain new insights into how contemporary antagonistic conflicts over culture unfold, and the roles of libraries and museums therein. At the same time, we wish to contribute to a deeper understanding of the transnational dynamics of far-right rhetoric, specifically the use of conspiratorial narratives about cultural decline and elite betrayal, and how it effects society's democratic infrastructure, of which libraries and museums form part. Hence, this analysis should be relevant not only for understanding current debates concerning the role of culture in Swedish society but also for exploring how far-right rhetoric contests and acts upon democratic infrastructure in liberal democracies.

The paper opens with an overview of relevant existing research on the culture wars, before introducing conspiracy theories and their intersections with populism and far-right rhetoric, with particular attention to the Swedish context. We then turn to our empirical site, YouTube and outline the methods and materials employed in the study. The article concludes with a presentation and discussion of our findings.

Cultural institutions in the culture wars

Across a number of countries in recent years, tensions between progressive and conservative views on culture have become increasingly pronounced and polarized. These forms of antagonistic conflicts, manifested through both the silencing of alternative perspectives, associated with progressive politics, and vitriolic online harassment associated with the far-right, have come to be referred to as the culture wars (Hunter, 1991; Hartman, 2018; Phelan, 2025). The concept remains contested and has itself been weaponized within the very conflicts it seeks to describe. Originating in late seventeenth-century Germany, the term has gained new currency in the wake of the MAGA movement's backlash against progressive cultural perspectives in the United States (cf. Jaeger, 2025), alongside the electoral successes of far-right parties in Europe (cf. Phelan, 2025). Although the term has entered Swedish public debate in recent years, there is an ongoing discussion regarding its suitability for describing the Swedish political context characterized by a stronger tradition of state trust and lower levels of polarization (e.g. Irenius, 2020). Recognizing that the concept itself is subject to debate, we still find it useful for describing the antagonistic conflicts over culture and society that are the focus of this paper.

There is a growing body of research addressing challenges to the field of cultural policy stemming from the culture wars and the far-right's strengthened position (Niklasson and Hølleland, 2018; Bonet and Zamorano, 2021; Harding, 2022), including the use of cultural policy and cultural institutions as symbols in establishment criticism (Usherwood and

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Usherwood, 2021; Hanell *et al.*, 2024). There are also studies of culture wars-related conflicts over collections and programming activities, addressing issues of censorship, neutrality and bias, as well as the autonomy of culture from politics (cf. Engström *et al.*, 2024; Larsen, 2025; Oltmann, 2026). Notably, cultural workers' experiences of navigating the polarization and conflicts associated with the culture wars have been studied, pointing to the rise of new ethical dilemmas, heightened incidence of hate speech, threats and self-censorship (Carlsson *et al.*, 2023; Chrastka, 2025; Hanell *et al.*, 2025b; Engman, 2025), as well as accusations of activism and elitism (cf. Kann-Rasmussen, 2023). In this article, we expand these studies of antagonistic conflicts over culture by turning our attention to how cultural institutions are mobilized in online far-right rhetoric. In the next section, we will go on to describe and define some central features of this rhetoric: the use of conspiracy theories and populism and their entanglement with far-right ideology.

Conspiracy theories, populism and far-right rhetoric

Even though conspiracy theories have not traditionally been a prominent feature of Swedish politics, Astapova and colleagues (2021) note a growing presence of conspiracy thinking in political and public discourses across the Nordic countries in recent years, particularly evident in far-right populist rhetoric. They further link this growing presence to the "cultural backlash" against progressive and libertarian cultural expressions (cf. Norris and Inglehart, 2019), associated with the culture war. As noted in previous research (cf. Bergmann and Butter, 2020), conspiracy narratives share many central features and rhetorical strategies with far-right rhetoric and populism. Of particular interest for this study is their centring on elite distrust as a collective point of convergence.

Beginning with populism, the main argument strongly maintains a view of society as fundamentally divided into two uniform and opposing groups, "the pure people" and "the corrupt elite", and that political decision-making should reflect the general will of "the pure people" (Mudde and Rovira Kaltwasser, 2017). This rhetorical trope has been used by populist politicians on the whole spectrum of the political scale. Populism is therefore widely theorized as a "thin-centred" ideology, meaning that it lacks a fully developed ideological structure and therefore tends to attach itself to more substantive ideologies such as nationalism, socialism or fascism (Bergmann and Butter, 2020). The study presented in this paper focuses the entanglement between far-right ideology and populism, which according to Wodak (2015) is not merely a rhetorical style but also defined by specific ideological content. The fear it incites is multi-faceted: it includes anxieties about economic insecurity, particularly the perceived threat of migrants displacing native workers or undermining welfare systems. It also invokes narratives of cultural decline, the erosion of national traditions and the alleged inability of the state to protect its citizens. Often, these anxieties are framed as the result of covert, coordinated efforts by powerful actors, revealing the central role of conspiratorial thinking within far-right populist discourse (Bergmann and Butter, 2020; see also Wodak, 2015).

As noted by Bergmann and Butter (2020), several studies emphasize the shared structural features of populism and conspiracy theories and highlights their common reliance on binary oppositions between the virtuous people and the corrupt elite, or between the informed few and the misled many. While populism emphasizes the moral purity and will of the people, conspiracy theories highlight their lack of awareness of hidden power structures. Bergmann and Butter (2020) further note that there have been scholarly recognitions of the significant overlap between populist and conspiracist worldviews. Both are frequently characterized as simplified responses to complex societal challenges such as globalization (e.g. Brubaker, 2019) and both are regularly cited as threats to liberal democracy and are strongly associated with extremist movements (e.g. van Prooijen, 2018).

Although the concept of conspiracy theory may be used in diverse and often contested ways across disciplines, the notion of secret elites pulling the strings behind critical events

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is something conspiracy narratives have in common (Astapova *et al.*, 2021). One widely cited definition, proposed by political scientists Uscinski and Parent (2014, p. 32), characterizes a conspiracy theory as "an explanation of historical, ongoing, or future events that cites as a main causal factor a small group of powerful persons [. . .] acting in secret for their own benefit against the common good." This definition is useful for the purpose of this paper as it points to the interconnections and overlaps between conspiracy theories, populism and far-right discourse, a synthesis often mobilized in contemporary political communication, particularly on digital platforms (Völker and Saldivia Gonzatti, 2024). Moreover, in the context of social media and platformization, it is also relevant to address conspiracy theories as transnationally shared online stories that circulate across borders through globalized media flows. Although often originating in the United States, conspiracy narratives are today spread, adapted and localized by online communities across diverse political and cultural contexts (Astapova *et al.*, 2021). Analytically, we therefore approach them as a specific type of shared online story, a perspective that will be further elaborated in the methods section.

Far-right ideology and conspiracy theories in digital spaces

Among the various parallels between far-right rhetoric, populism and conspiracy theories, a significant point of convergence lies in their mutual exploitation of digital media environments. Both populist and conspiracist worldviews tend to thrive within the affordances of the digital landscape. This is especially evident in online echo chambers and alternative media platforms that operate as counter-publics, where dominant norms are contested and oppositional narratives gain traction (van Kessel and Castelein, 2016).

Recent years have seen a growing body of interdisciplinary scholarship examining the digital presence and rhetorical strategies of the far right. Studies have addressed the discursive construction of far-right ideology in online contexts (Cervi *et al.*, 2023; Hanell *et al.*, 2025a; Wahlström *et al.*, 2021), the dynamics of group formation and communicative ties within far-right online communities (Åkerlund, 2021; Scrivens, 2021), and the normalization and repackaging of extremist narratives in digital environments (Tuters and Hagen, 2020). These studies collectively highlight how the far right has become adept at leveraging digital media infrastructures to build and sustain ideological networks. A prominent theme within this literature is the sociomaterial enablement of far-right discourse, particularly the affordances of social media platforms that facilitate the circulation and persistence of polarizing content. Research has shown how anonymity (Törnberg and Törnberg, 2024), algorithmic amplification (Gaudette *et al.*, 2021) and platform design (Munn, 2020) create conducive environments for conspiracy narratives and culture wars rhetoric to thrive. This has contributed to what Völker and Saldivia Gonzatti (2024) describe as the "mainstreaming" of far-right ideology in digital spaces.

Among these platforms, YouTube has emerged as a critical infrastructure in the dissemination of far-right content (Munger and Phillips, 2022). The role of the platform in extending the reach of far-right ideas has also drawn increasing scholarly attention. For example, Klinger and colleagues (2023) document how content from fringe extremist groups is repurposed and reframed for broader political campaigns. Similarly, multimodal analyses from Finland (Salojärvi *et al.*, 2023) illustrate how nostalgia, war myths, and misogyny are employed in YouTube campaign videos to create polarizing in-group/out-group dynamics and Russo and Blikstein (2023) show how YouTube videos featuring Brazil's former right-wing president Jair Bolsonaro exploit human cognitive tendencies to disseminate unsubstantiated narratives. Thematically, research has examined far-right YouTube discourse on the so-called refugee crisis (Rauchfleisch and Kaiser, 2020), "wokeness" and cultural decline (Brett, 2025) and environmental conspiracies (Salles *et al.*, 2023). In response to such practices, YouTube have adopted content moderation strategies such as deplatforming (Rauchfleisch and Kaiser, 2021), which in turn has led some far-right creators to migrate to alternative platforms like

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BitChute and Gab Social (Collins, 2025). Nevertheless, YouTube continues to serve as an important channel for the spread of far-right content, also in the Swedish context.

Materials and methods

This article is concerned with how conspiracy narratives unfold in the context of the culture wars, and how cultural institutions are embedded in these shared stories. As argued by Page (2018), the study of shared online stories necessitates an integrated approach that draws on multiple analytical frameworks and methods for data collection. To foster this form of methodological synergy, we chose to apply a nexus approach, combining data-driven methods and the text analytical capabilities of large language models with in-depth qualitative analysis in the form of *Mediated narrative analysis*. YouTube was chosen as the site for data collection, because of its position as a critical node in the contemporary information infrastructure, where platform logics and algorithmic amplification play a central role in the circulation and visibility of far-right content. The data collection proceeded in two steps:

In the initial stage, material consisting of 3,549 YouTube videos from 11 channels with connections to the Swedish far-right was collected using the YouTube API. Due to the limitations of the API, the full backlog of videos from each channel was not collected. The dataset covers the period from April 2012 up until April 2025. The videos are mainly Swedish language, although components in Danish, English and Russian are also found. Transcription was carried out using the Whisper Turbo model through Open AI's Python library (Radford *et al.*, 2022), which is effective on multilingual and Swedish materials. While a resource fine-tuned for Swedish, such as KB Labs' alternative (Vesterbacka *et al.*, 2025) would likely provide a higher precision for the Swedish language materials, this initial transcription was conducted using a multilingual model so that the language distribution of the dataset could be understood. Quotes of Swedish transcriptions have been translated into English by the authors.

In the second stage, eight videos from the YouTube channel Riks were selected for qualitative analysis. Riks, which primarily operates as a conservative Swedish news outlet, was launched in 2022 and initially owned by the leading far-right party in Sweden: The Sweden Democrats (SD). The news outlet was sold in 2024 and is currently owned by a private company, which claims to be independent from SD (Wikipedia, 2025). The videos from Riks were selected due to their specific focus on libraries and museums and due to their high viewership. Mirroring the selection for the qualitative analysis, the larger dataset used for the quantitative analysis was filtered for channels sharing Riks' main characteristics, meaning a clear connection to SD and its political views. After filtering, the dataset included 1,312 transcribed videos from three different channels: Riks (526 videos), Riks Morgongänget (284 videos) and Sverigedemokraterna (502 videos).

Proceeding to the analysis, the larger dataset was used to conduct topic modelling using BERTopic (Grootendorst, 2022), producing 39 topics and one outlier topic (Appendix 1, with outlier labelled as topic −1). The topic model was used to map and produce an overview of topics addressed within the larger sample from all three channels. To produce methodological synergy, the results were then compared with and contextualized using the results from the qualitative analysis of the eight selected videos. The qualitative analysis was in turn contextualized using results from the topic model. *Mediated narrative analysis (MNA)* was used as an overarching framework for studying the multimodality of YouTube content and to analytically approach far-right conspiracy theories as a distinct form of shared online stories, circulating transnationally through globalized information infrastructures, while being recontextualized and rearticulated by online communities across diverse political and cultural contexts (Astapova *et al.*, 2021). Inspired by MNA, we chose to analyse our qualitative data on three levels, specifically adapted to the transnational character of our object of study. At the first level of analysis, we identified and defined the main conspiracy narratives, paying specific attention to how they intersect with far-right populism. At the second level, we focused on tracing the narratives' intertextual links, concentrating on how meaning is

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produced through invoking cultural and historical symbols and imaginings. Finally, at the third level of analysis, we sought to disclose the narratives' embeddedness in the culture wars, their recontextualization when situated in the Swedish context, and how museums and libraries are positioned in the plot. This closer attention to narrative meant that, for the purposes of this study, we paid less attention to the material and sociotechnical dimensions of YouTube as a platform, such as algorithmic amplification and user practices like commenting and upvoting content.

Results and analysis

In this section, we present the findings from the nexus analysis of the YouTube material. At the first level of analysis, three main narrative clusters were identified: "*deep-state" conspiracy narratives; conspiracy narratives of "wokeism"*; and "*great replacement" conspiracy narratives*. In what follows, these narrative clusters function as themes that structure the presentation of the analysis. Quotes from the videos serve as illustrative examples of the presence of respective narrative cluster and are subsequently discussed in relation to the issues addressed at the second and third levels of the analysis.

Museums and libraries as platforms for "deep state" propaganda

The transnational character and influence on the online stories studied in the current paper is visible in the topic model produced based on the transcribed videos, as both discussions on US politics (topics 8, 10 and 38 in Appendix 1) and English language segments are found as recurring topics. Topic 8 is centred on Donald Trump, 10 on US policy on the Russian invasion of Ukraine and 38 on cultural policy. These themes are also reflected in the temporal trends of the topics, as shown in Figure 1. It is noteworthy that topic 38 occurs at a lower frequency, but the topic is consistently found throughout the period represented in the sample.

A recurring topic in the larger dataset is "The Social Democrats", one of the major political parties in Sweden. The representation of topic 2 being "will_are going to _The Social Democrats_Sweden [1]" which combines the Social Democrats with action verbs indicating what will happen if the party is given influence and including Sweden as the recipient of those actions. The verbs indicate that the discussion is mainly concerned with what is going to happen and the outcomes of current positions, rather than implicating the party in prior events.

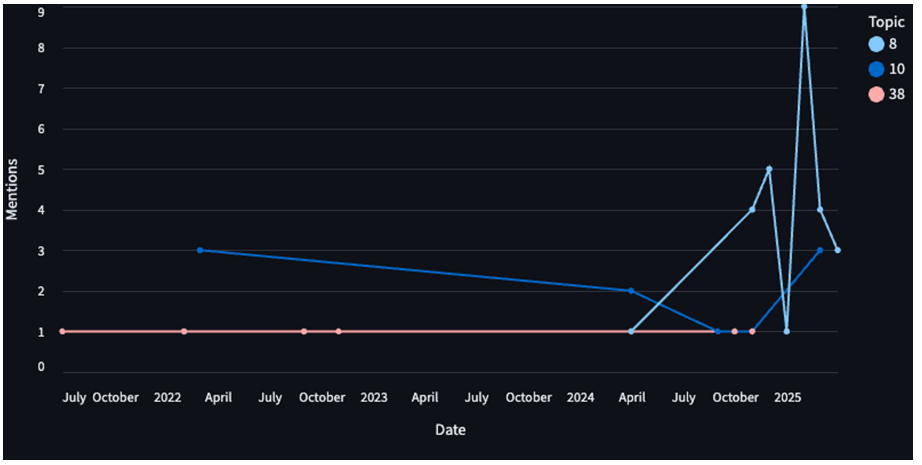


Figure 1. Temporal trends for topics 8, 10 and 38. Source: Authors' own work

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The trend shows that the topic is found throughout the sample, as seen in Figure 2, with a spike in the trend surrounding specific party leaders during the autumn of 2024.

The qualitative analysis reflects the larger data sample, with the Social Democratic Party clearly present as a topic of concern in the selected videos. This is not surprising. The Social Democratic Party, governing for most of the twentieth century and playing a central role in shaping the modern Swedish welfare state, is frequently portrayed by the far-right as a symbol of the political elite and as a traitor to the people (Astapova *et al.*, 2021; Håkansson, 2023). Within far-right discourse, the party is often accused of covertly attempting to indoctrinate society and is recurrently implicated in stories of conspiracy and institutional cover-ups (Astapova *et al.*, 2021). As such, these narratives represent a local adaptation of so called deep state conspiracy narratives, which posit the existence of covert networks operating within state bureaucracies to subvert democratic governance and impose authoritarian control. Although rooted in American political discourse, they easily resonate within local contexts by being reframed through domestic lenses of suspicion and distrust. In Sweden, narratives of "deep state" conspiracies have been translated into the context of the welfare state and its perceived decline, which is often attributed to The Social Democrats (Astapova *et al.*, 2021).

The overall discourse in the selected videos reflects this local adaptation of the deep state conspiracy narrative. The Social Democrats are continuously portrayed as part of a larger system of left-wing indoctrination, accused of steering political developments outside democratic processes and pushing society towards totalitarianism. Museums and libraries are in turn presented as tools within this system, used to spread an ideological agenda. This is exemplified in the video titled *"Malmö City Library Buys Drag Queens – Cannot Afford Books,"* in which the leader of Malmölistan [the Malmö list], a local right-wing populist party, is interviewed by the media outlet Riks. In this context, it is important to note that the city of Malmö, traditionally an industrial city and a stronghold of the Social Democrats, today is a Swedish symbol of progressive, post-industrial and multicultural politics, currently governed by the Social Democrats in a coalition with the Green Party and the Liberal Party. Positioned in front of the Malmö City Library, the leader of Malmölistan gestures with a copy of George Orwell's classic dystopian novel *1984* as a rhetorical device to underscore his message:

> It's not just about these Drag Queens. The real issue is that the whole library in Malmö is filled with politically biased propaganda all about LGBTQI+++. And look, I've got nothing against people with different sexual orientations. I think everyone should be able to love whoever they want. But that's not what this is about. This is a political movement. Take, for example, the recent decision in Parliament

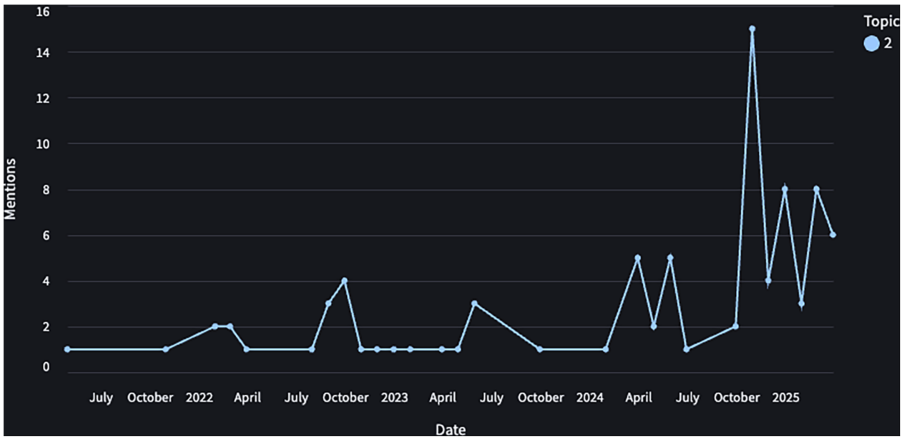


Figure 2. Temporal trend for topic 2. Source: Authors' own work

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> that made it easier for kids to change their gender. That was a political move passed with a two-thirds majority, even though, according to a [. . .] opinion poll, two-thirds of the Swedish public were against it. So this is definitely a political issue, tied to LGBTQ topics, gender changes, and Drag Queens.

As he speaks, the background visuals shift to interior footage of the library, prominently displaying a rainbow flag positioned above the entrance and informational leaflets in similar rainbow colours arranged on a shelve. Given the context, the visual elements of flags and leaflets serve to reinforce the speaker's framing of the library as a spreader of propaganda.

> And I don't think it's the municipality's job to lecture people or tell residents what to think about these things. Especially not in a library, which is supposed to be a neutral place where you can borrow a book and make up your own mind, without being influenced by state or local government propaganda. Otherwise, we're heading into 1984 territory, you know, that famous book by George Orwell where Big Brother and the government tell people what they're supposed to think.

The notion that libraries compromise their neutrality by engaging with LGBTQ-related issues is not unique to this setting but a recurring rhetorical trope within far-right discourse, as well as in broader culture war debates observed in Sweden and internationally (Engström *et al.*, 2024). The concept of library neutrality has for long been a highly contested terrain in both research and professional practice (e.g. Kann-Rasmussen *et al*., 2022; Høj Mathiasson and Jochumsen, 2023; Solum, 2025), with no clear consensus on how it should be defined or navigated. In the material analysed, a further layer is added to this debate as claims about compromised library neutrality are drawn into a broader conspiracy narrative of Social Democratic indoctrination and the threat of an Orwellian dystopia invoked by the speaker. It is a locally adapted "deep state" conspiracy narrative, invoking culturally specific understandings of the relationship between "the people" and "the elite", in which Malmö City Library comes forth as both tool and representative of Social Democratic hegemony. However, it also situates this local library within a larger international struggle over the perceived politicization and ideological framing of LGBTQ rights, which will be further discussed in relation to the conspiracy narrative on "wokeism".

A further example, showcasing the idea of Social Democratic betrayal is a video titled "*The new S-proposal against future Koran riots: more libraries*". In this clip, the SD spokesperson for cultural policy is interviewed about a recent debate in national parliament. The SD politician questions the Social Democratic Minister of Culture on the role of Swedish culture in integration policies, situating the inquiry within the context of recent riots sparked by provocative Quran burnings. The SD-politician explains in an agitated, yet sarcastic tone:

> **SD:** [. . .] The riots we saw during the Easter weekend — one contributing factor to them is precisely the lack of integration and understanding of how Sweden works, how Swedish culture functions. So I asked the Minister of Culture what measures she intends to introduce to help new citizens learn about Sweden and how Swedish culture works.
>
> **Reporter:** And what answer did you get?
>
> **SD:** Well, of course, I didn't get any answer about whether we have a Swedish culture, because the minister refuses to acknowledge that. Instead, she started talking about how we should bring more culture into Sweden. And one of her answers was that more libraries should be opened. So that was her response to how we should integrate our new citizens.

One of the most reoccurring and forceful "deep-state" accusations launched by SD at the Social Democrats is their alleged conspiring to erase so-called authentic Swedish culture (Astapova *et al.*, 2021; cf. Håkansson, 2023). To SD, successful integration implies assimilation to a recognized Swedish lifestyle and Swedish values (cf. Nordensvard and Ketola, 2015). The Social Democrats' focus on promoting diversity and a multicultural society, without defining Swedish culture proper, thereby implies a betrayal to the Swedish "pure people". The video constitutes an example of how libraries become entangled in this conflict. As the SD politician accuses the minister of not acknowledging the existence of a

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Swedish culture, the Social Democrats put libraries forth as *their* response to how culture in a broad sense should be promoted. In this way they are, in a sense, claiming ownership of the public library institution, which thereby is constructed as a Social Democratic tool for integration and multiculturalism, connected to the SD dystopia of the national majority culture being turned into a minority (cf. Håkansson, 2023).

The above analysed videos thus exemplify how libraries can become part of "deep state" discourses that draw on international imaginaries of systemic manipulation but are localized through the interpretive work of individual gatekeepers and community actors, in this case the leader of Malmölistan and the SD politician. In this way, global conspiracy narratives are translated into specific cultural idioms, reflecting and reinforcing local anxieties and political imaginaries. The analysed videos invoke a long-standing far-right criticism of the Social Democratic Party for having abandoned the interests of the "the pure Swedish people" in favour of what is perceived as a naïve celebration of minority rights. Within this narrative, contemporary Social Democrats are portrayed as deceitful and detached elites, which are alienated from both the historical foundations of the party and the realities of present-day society. This sense of betrayal positions the Social Democrats and the broader political left as part of an elite establishment, disconnected from "the people" (Astapova *et al.*, 2021). Libraries, and Malmö City Library in particular, are discursively positioned as serving the interests of this elite and as part of a larger ideological apparatus seeking to undermine the will of "the people".

Promoting "wokeism"

A further example of the idea of cultural institutions as platforms of propaganda is displayed in the video entitled "Wokeness has infiltrated our museums". In this case, however, it is a more diffuse leftist elite that are seen to be pulling the strings. Seated against a bluescreen backdrop depicting the Swedish National Museum, a young woman dressed in formal attire addresses the audience in American-accented English, using a sarcastic tone:

> So, I was in the Swedish National Museum here in Stockholm the other day, and what I thought was going to be a very nice experience surrounded by historical richness and beauty actually turned into a woke brainwashing session that drove me kind of crazy. So, we all know how museums, they have these little description signs, right, next to all the artworks in order to say something about the title and usually about the style of the work. Well, no longer. Nowadays, those have become apparently little manifestos in order for woke activists to indoctrinate you.

In this brief introduction, the notion of subversion from an enemy within is evoked using terms such as "brainwashing," "manifestos" and "indoctrination." These choices of wording resemble expressions of longstanding conspiracy narratives, most notably articulated in the United States, of Cultural Marxism as infiltrating the media and entertainment industry and the education system (cf. Smith *et al.*, 2023). In the video, these ideas are imported into Swedish far-right discourse and integrated with contemporary fears of the social threat thought to be posed by authoritarian "woke ideology" or "woke religion", ideas similarly rooted in American cultural and political discourse.

The term "Woke" stems from the phrase "stay woke," which emerged within African American communities as a call to remain alert to systemic oppression and civil rights issues within African American communities (Romano, 2020). Over time, the term has evolved and become politically charged and is both used affirmatively to describe individuals or institutions that are conscious of, and responsive to, issues of social justice, including racial inequality, gender rights, LGBTQ + inclusion, climate justice and decolonization. However, it is also increasingly used sarcastically or critically, especially in culture wars, right-wing discourse, to label what opponents view as excessive political correctness, performative activism or ideological overreach in institutions, media or education (Davies and MacRae, 2023). This pejorative tonality is clearly present in the video and the connections made to the

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US political landscape is underlined by the woman speaking in an American accent. In a sarcastic tone, she goes on to explain in more detail what agitated her about the visit to the Swedish National Museum:

> / . . . / what does the Swedish National Museum want you to know about this painting? Maybe something about the artist and how he was a frontrunner in the 19th century in terms of realism? Well, no, not quite. The National Museum actually wants you to know the following: "Female models had low status being viewed as little more than a commodity and the property of male artists. When Jo examined herself in the mirror, it was a vital act as she was entirely dependent on her appearance to make a living". And it doesn't stop there. Whilst they're at it, they'll also lecture you a little bit about contemporary times, stating that, and I quote, "In the consumer culture of today, women are defined by their appearance, not allowed to age, and controlled by their weight". Yeah, it's almost admirable how much they managed to put crap into a description about just a really pretty portrait.

The video exemplifies how issues identified as "woke", in this case gender rights, often becomes a discursive battleground in the culture wars, where one side sees it as a commitment to equity and justice, and the other sees it as a form of ideological indoctrination or moral overreach. "Woke", then functions as a symbolic shorthand in broader debates about identity politics, cultural polarization and in the analysed video, the politicization of public cultural institutions. Drawing on conspiracy narratives suggesting that a left-leaning cultural elite controls the cultural sector (Davies and MacRae, 2023), the National Museum is framed as an instrument or platform for such ideological influence. The employees at the museum are in turn portrayed as part of this conspiring cultural leftist elite who are not merely misrepresenting the past, what in anti-wokeness discourse often is referred to as an unpatriotic act of "cancelling our history" (Davies and MacRae, 2023, p. 21; see also Smith *et al.*, 2023), but also seeking to ruin the present by promoting "wokeness". The woman continues in an agitated tone:

> See, that's the thing here. These leftists who dominate the art sector are imposing their own worldview on us without any historical or factual basis. And don't limit themselves to, let's just say, misinterpreting the past / . . . /. So, please, do us all a favour, go ahead and study again some gender theory and go and write something for a left-wing journal if you're into unfactual propaganda. But please, leave us and art alone.

This rhetoric further aligns with broader international anti-wokeness campaigns, positioning "woke" as a social threat. Davies and MacRae (2023, p. 6) found that the discourse surrounding "anti-wokeness" in the UK has increasingly framed "woke" as a "dangerous, punitive and subversive, Stalinist, Maoist, "totalitarian" ideology or pseudo-religion". The use of the pseudo-religious framing is also found in the analysed Swedish material, specifically in a video titled "The next big tax-funded initiative: rainbow librarians" sarcastically criticizing a new initiative in the town of Västerås introducing rainbow librarians, specialists on LGBTQ issues and literature:

> Do the LGBTQ movement need their own librarians? Apparently, yes, at least if you ask the municipality of Västerås. As we all know, the LGBTQ, A, B, C, D, E, F, G, H, 2, 3, 4, 5 plus movement, that movement with 175 different pronouns, has become the new civic religion. (14 seconds pause) Rainbow flags are now expected on buildings, products, and logos. Even the Church of Sweden has converted to the LGBTQ religion. Last autumn, a digital LGBTQ conference titled Trans Blessing was organized by the Church of Sweden in Västerås. And woe to anyone who thinks this is too much because then you're labeled transphobic, homophobic, or some other kind of phobic. So what's happening in Västerås now? Well, the city library in Västerås has become the first public library in Sweden to introduce "rainbow librarians", specialists in literature and issues related to LGBTQ+.

Again, libraries are implicated in what is framed as plots of indoctrination and threats to the established social order. The construction of "woke" as a civic religion converges with the discursive logics of conspiracy theories and populism, foregrounding the exclusion of non-adherents as cultural outcasts. Woke has further been depicted as "the opiate of the elite"

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(Pattersson, 2021), a populist inversion of Marx's classic description of religion as the "opium of the people." In this narrative, "woke" is constructed as an ideology infiltrating policy, higher education and in this case museums and libraries, thereby representing a broader threat to the nation and as a challenge to the status quo.

Cultural institutions as vehicles for "great replacement" conspiracy theories

Museums and public libraries are also incorporated in myths suggesting that western civilization is under threat. One of the videos entitled "Arabic at the libraries in Malmö and Helsingborg" [the two largest cities in the southernmost region of Sweden] seeks to invoke sentiments of Swedes and the Swedish language as being driven out and replaced by Arab-speaking Muslim immigrants. In an interview on Riks, with a local SD-politician and a political far right-wing commentator, recent political decisions to allow the building of a mosque in the city of Helsingborg and to train librarians in Arabic is criticized. The tone shifts between sarcasm and irritation:

> **Reporter**: But / . . . /, is it really necessary in Helsingborg for people to learn conversational Arabic? Is that how we're going to fix these problems?
>
> **Commentator**: Well, when you walk through certain neighbourhoods in Helsingborg, it's almost a necessity just to get by as a Swede. But that's not how it should be. We're already pouring huge amounts of money into Swedish for immigrants and other programs. And still, we have people who need interpreters to speak Swedish even though they've lived in Sweden for 15 or 20 years. Society is doing everything it can to help integrate people and teach them Swedish. But despite that, it seems we've given up completely, because not only is information available in Arabic, now we're training Swedes to speak Arabic too. Instead of expecting newcomers to learn our language.

Although allocation of public funding of course is a legitimate political concern, the critique presented in the video rather follows a familiar line of reasoning used by SD, reflecting several elements of the so-called Eurabia conspiracy theory (cf. Håkansson, 2023). This theory refers to the fear of Muslims replacing the Christian population or that Muslims are infiltrating the West with help from domestic traitors. The theory has been promoted, either openly or indirectly, by SD and their leader Jimmie Åkesson, during their rise to the national parliament (Astapova *et al.*, 2021; see also Nordensvard and Ketola, 2015). In the narrative of SD, immigration failure is framed as the perceived collapse and betrayal of Social Democratic rule, which is portrayed as having abandoned the interests of the "pure" or native population (cf. Håkansson, 2023). SD have frequently presented Sweden as a warning example of unregulated multiculturalism, using this framing to advocate harsher immigration laws and stronger assimilation policies (Astapova *et al.*, 2021). In the analysed video, the domestic traitors are instead the other conservative parties that do not seek support from SD in local parliament, which accordingly are accused of being hypocritical, failing to uphold the values they endorse on social media and in national parliament. This perceived discrepancy is constructed as a betrayal, both to SD and to the will of "the pure people", leaving SD as the only true voice safeguarding Sweden (cf. Håkansson, 2023). Librarians are repeatedly mentioned, not as active agents but as victims or tools used to stage the ongoing treason:

> **Reporter [sarcastically]:** They're [the other conservative parties] saying that being against teaching Arabic to library staff is assimilation, and that assimilation is something bad. They even called it undemocratic and hateful.
>
> / . . . /
>
> **SD-politician [agitated]**: Exactly, solidarity, compassion, [liberal] slogans and all that. There are still plenty of people at the local level who think that way and see the Sweden Democrats as the Nazis making a comeback. But reality is what it is, and if we keep going in the same direction as we have for the last 30 years, it won't just be library staff who have to learn Arabic, Arabic will become the majority language. And I don't want that.

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> **Commentator[agitated]**: We might be getting close already, we've got library staff being taught conversational Arabic. So what's the next step? Are we going to start teaching conversational Arabic in our schools? That's the question./ . . . /

Both above quotes reflect ideas about how integration in Sweden has failed, and how this poses a threat to national identity. They also perpetuate a dystopia narrative, reproduced by SD, in which the political elite, represented by the other parties in local government, are depicted as actively orchestrating processes of erasure of majority culture, using library staff as tools (cf. Håkansson, 2023). This rhetoric ties into a broader and more widely spread conspiracy narrative, referred to as "the great replacement theory" (cf. Ekman, 2014). This conspiracy theory contends that European civilization and identity are under existential threat due to mass migration, particularly from Muslim-majority countries, and declining birth rates among the native population. The idea has been widely propagated by various nationalist and populist leaders across Europe, fuelling myths that political elites and migrants are systematically displacing national cultures and heritage (Astapova *et al.*, 2021).

The fear of cultural erasure and notions that national identity is under threat is present across the analysed material and explicitly pronounced in the video titled "The battle over culture – shall the will of the people or the cultural left govern". In the video, a SD politician, recently appointed as chairman of a county museum, is interviewed regarding how one of his tweets ignited a heated debate about his appointment:

> Yes, it all started with my tweet where I said that we should once again focus on Swedish history and cultural heritage. And then people interpreted that as if I'm going to walk into the County Museum and take down paintings I don't like and put up the ones I do like. But that's not really how it works. The main purpose of my tweet was to highlight that the Social Democrats, for a very long time, have been working intensively to erase Swedish history and cultural heritage. Because they have no interest in promoting it in relation to their international policies and their goal of creating a multicultural society.

In both these examples, libraries and museums are portrayed both as tools and as victims of a Social Democrat and leftist regime that threatens the Swedish nation by promoting diversity and multiculturalism at the expense of Swedish language and cultural heritage, in effect making the institutions tools for the governing elite. With the growing support for SD and nationalistic and conservative values, the cultural institutions are seen to be given back their freedom from this undue political control, enabling them to leverage what the far-right perceive as these institutions' core assignments: to promote and protect Swedish culture (cf. Håkansson, 2023).

Transnational influence and rhetorical vilification

The above analysis shows how populist and conspiracist worldviews converge in online culture wars discourse, with far-right rhetoric using libraries and museums to reinforce and amplify distrust toward elites. The three narrative clusters collect three interrelated, but distinct, types of conspiracy narratives: "*deep-state*", "*wokeism*" and "*great replacement*" conspiracy narratives. In narratives about "deep-state" conspiracies, the Social Democrats are framed as being part of a global system of left-wing indoctrination, pushing society towards totalitarianism and the erasure of "authentic Swedish culture". Through promoting diversity, cultural institutions are portrayed as politicised instruments for integration and multiculturalism. In the "wokeism" conspiracy narratives a vaguely framed leftist elite is seen as responsible for infiltrating and subverting cultural institutions into authoritarian ideological overreach and "woke" is described as a civic religion promoting political correctness and performative activism. Conspiracy narratives about the "great replacement" (cf. Ekman, 2014) draw upon myths of western decline and portray libraries and museums as both tools and as victims of a malign leftist regime threatening the nation by promoting diversity and multiculturalism at the expense of Swedish language and culture, and SD is framed as the only real safeguard against cultural erasure and the loss of national identity.

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These results show how both libraries and museums are rhetorically used to foster those anxieties that Wodak (2015) identifies as characteristic of far-right populism: the imagined threat of migrants displacing the native population and undermining welfare provisions, fears of cultural decline, the erosion of national traditions and a presumed inability of the state to serve the people's interest and to safeguard its citizens. Considering public libraries and museums as components of a democratic infrastructure (e.g. Audunson *et al.*, 2019, 2020), this rhetoric thereby directly challenges established conceptions of their democratic mission and societal functions.

In Sweden and elsewhere, public libraries have historically been tied to the emergence of democratic governance, providing an alternative to a cultural and public sphere reserved for elites (e.g. Buschman, 2003; Hansson, 2010). Understood as "the people's libraries", they are in Sweden legislatively mandated to remain open and accessible to all (Carlsson *et al.*, 2023; Engström, 2022). Within the analysed far-right videos, however, libraries are rhetorically recast as instruments, victims or at times even as agents, of a corrupt elite that no longer serves the people's interests. Museums, similarly, are portrayed as detached from the general will of "the pure people" and in the context of so-called wokeism, as actively deceiving the populace on behalf of an ideologically laden elite. Rhetorically, such deception comes forth as particularly problematic given that museums and libraries have historically been regarded as institutions of enlightenment. To this day, they remain vital to democratic infrastructure, functioning as arenas of public education and debate that strive to cultivate an informed and empowered citizenry (e.g. Audunson *et al.*, 2020; Koizumi and Larsen, 2023), rather than a misled or deceived one. In the analysed videos, museums and libraries are instead rhetorically vilified, being either portrayed as agents of an imagined conspiratorial elite, intent on deception, or dismissed as mere representatives of the deceived masses. Regardless, the institutions are accused of failing their mission and to serve those interests that they should be serving, that is the interest of "the pure people".

This framing constitutes an example of how the convergence of far-right populism and conspiracy theories can be mobilized rhetorically to undermine trust and credibility in democratic infrastructures (cf. Astapova *et al.*, 2021; Bergmann and Butter, 2020). By accusing these institutions not only of neglecting their "proper users" but also of siding with those perceived as the "wrong users," their legitimacy as institutions "for all" is fundamentally called into question. This is further reinforced by the notion that museums and libraries are promoting, or even indoctrinating, people with a certain ideologically laden agenda (cf. Hanell *et al.*, 2025a). Consequently, museums and libraries are accused of not being neutral and their employees of being activists rather than civil servants (Kann-Rasmussen, 2023). In this context, neutrality should not be understood as an ideal the far-right seeks to realize. Rather, the dichotomy constructed between activism and neutrality comes forth as a trope and rhetorical devise for promoting far-right populist conspiracy theories of elite-driven propaganda and covert indoctrination. Thus, accusations of partiality function as a strategic tool for discrediting both democratic infrastructures and political opponents.

Moreover, perceptions of what counts as neutral or ideologically motivated remain a contested issue (e.g. Eckerdal, 2018; Jaeger *et al.*, 2013; Kann-Rasmussen, 2023; Nissen and Kann-Rasmussen, 2025; Scott and Saunders, 2021; Solum, 2025), continuously reshaped by the political landscape. In Sweden, this is evident in the growing salience and shifting character of debates over minority rights. What was long regarded as a largely uncontested aspect of safeguarding universal human rights has, partially through the importation of the culture wars, been reframed as an ideology, or even as a form of secular creed. So, while the work of libraries and museums in this area have not undergone considerable change, reactions to this work from conservative politicians and parts of the public have (DIK, 2025). In this way, the "wokeism" conspiracy narrative differs from the other identified conspiracy narratives encountered in the study as it appears more resilient to local adaptations.

Recontextualization and local adjustments could on the other hand be easily identified both with "the deep state" and "the great replacement"- conspiracy theories. In the case of the

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Swedish articulation of "the deep state" conspiracy narrative, the Social Democratic Party, historically credited with building the Swedish welfare state, or "the Peoples home", is portrayed as complicit in its ruining through failed integration and the promotion of multiculturalism. Within this narrative, cultural institutions such as libraries and museums are depicted as instruments facilitating the alleged erasure of Swedish ethnicity and cultural heritage. These existential fears are deeply entwined with national symbols, notably "the Peoples home" and the Nordic welfare model, both of which carry longstanding historical significance and are closely linked to narratives of Swedish national identity (Astapova *et al.*, 2021;, cf. Salojärvi *et al.*, 2023). In both "the deep state" and "great replacement" conspiracy narratives, the perceived threat to Sweden is framed as an assault on the welfare state and the cultural values that defined the nation in the previous century.

In contrast, the conspiracy narrative surrounding "wokeism" appear less rooted in Swedish political traditions and instead manifests as a transnational discourse embedded within the contemporary culture wars, enabled by the dynamics of social media, YouTube accessibility and platform design. This narrative is in our material reproduced wholesale, with arguments imported without notable local adaptations. In the videos, advocates of diversity are portrayed as authoritarians who coercively impose acceptance of minority rights. However, the protection of these rights is a core component of the Swedish welfare state's compensatory mission (e.g. Carlsson *et al.*, 2023). Hence, whereas values associated with the welfare state in the other narratives are presented as something to be safeguarded, the "wokeism" conspiracy narrative reframes them as a threat. Here, the conspiracy narrative appears to shape the understanding of the local context, rather than the other way around.

Concluding remarks

This article sheds light on how far-right rhetoric contests and acts against democratic infrastructures by exploiting elite distrust and calling the legitimacy of established institutions, in this case museums and libraries, into question. By exploiting the enablements of YouTube and drawing on conspiratorial narratives of corrupt elites that no longer serves the people's interests, libraries and museums are rhetorically recast as tools, victims or at times even as agents of indoctrination and cultural erasure.

The long-term effects of this rhetoric on public trust in these institutions, and in liberal democratic governance as such, are yet to be studied. Existing research indicates that young people engage with conspiracy theories critically and just for fun (Haider and Sundin, 2022) and that controversies concerning "wokeism" is by many perceived of as online phenomena with no real bearing on daily life (Smith *et al.*, 2023). However, there are also indications that so-called conspiratorial thinking is increasing in Sweden (Strömbäck, 2022) and that young people perceive conspiracy theorists as relatable and more trustworthy than established institutions (Haider and Sundin, 2022). Furthermore, in a recent survey by the Swedish trade union DIK (2025), 17% of public librarians indicate that their library proactively avoid topics, such as LGBTQI issues diversity/multilingualism, gender/equality and national minorities, that may provoke strong reactions or pose a security risk (DIK, 2025, p. 36; see also Hanell *et al.*, 2025b). This suggests that both the long- and short-term effects on museums and libraries of far-right rhetoric and conspiratory narratives is a matter that warrants further study. We therefore encourage future research to further explore the potential consequences for institutional trust in public libraries and museums, as well as for these institutions' capacity to uphold and strengthen democratic resilience.

In addition, there is an urgent need to consider the safety implications of the conspiracy framings of museums and libraries surfacing in this study. The rhetoric employed in the analysed videos, and the settings in which it is delivered, appear tidy, avoiding explicit calls for provocation or violence. Even so, the potential consequences of the ideas they promote should be taken seriously. As mentioned, conspiracy narratives have previously not been pronounced and mainstreamed in the Nordic countries, but they have been nurtured in far-right contexts

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(Astapova *et al.*, 2021). In its most extreme forms, such narratives have sparked acts of violence, most notably the murders committed by Norwegian terrorist Anders Behring Breivik. In his justification for the 2011 terrorist attacks in Norway, he referenced conspiracy theories, which lead to him targeting young members of the Labour Party, whom he accused of being "cultural Marxists" and for being complicit in the destruction of Nordic heritage through promoting feminism and multiculturalism (Astapova *et al.*, 2021; Davies and MacRae, 2023). This suggests that the use of far-right tropes, in combination with the nurturing of conspiracy myths of complotting elites, can have severe implications, both for those targeted and for democracy and society at large. As librarians and museum professionals become entangled in these narratives, they risk being targeted by such misguided antagonisms, antagonisms that may also pose a threat to liberal democracy itself.

Appendix

Table A1. Topic representation table for dataset

Topic	Topic_Keywords
−1	−1_the_ska_kommer_in
0	0_the_to_it_and
1	1_ja_ska_bara_s√§ga
2	2_ska_kommer_socialdemokraterna_sverige
3	3_sverige_ska_kommer_personer
4	4_polisen_ska_kommer_brott
5	5_the_that_it_to
6	6_the_to_and_it
7	7_ska_vill_kommer_också
8	8_trump_usa_donald_kommer
9	9_polisen_ska_ocks√•_kommer
10	10_ryssland_usa_trump_kriget
11	11_fäst_skruva_loss_ska
12	12_muslimer_ska_sverige_kommer
13	13_power_the_wind_kärnkraft
14	14_kyrkan_ska_svenska_vill
15	15_the_to_in_that
16	16_carcobye_coolest_beedle_hac
17	17_sverige_mati_tu_vire
18	18_ska_klimatet_mer_kommer
19	19_sverige_svenska_svenskarna_000
20	20_ska_vill_kommer_f√•r
21	21_спокойная_sverige_музыка_ska
22	22_Israel_palestina_kommer_ska
23	23_download_error__
24	24_pengar_miljarder_skatt_kronor
25	25_kvinnor_ska_ja_kanske
26	26_sverige_kommer_ska_ja
27	27_liksom_ska_också_bara
28	28_rasism_ska_kommer_gör
29	29_lärare_skolan_ska_tack
30	30_og_jeg_at_ikke
31	31_också•_europa_finns_sverige
32	32_the_that_to_they
33	33_culture_музыка_the_that
34	34_ja_ska_bara_får

(*continued*)

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Table A1. Continued

Topic	Topic_Keywords
35	35_eu_europa_sverige_ska
36	36_tack_thomas_priserna_priset
37	37_the_and_of_it
38	38_kultur_usa_tack_lidingar
39	39_you_thank_much_very

Note

1. Swedish: ska_kommer_socialdemokraterna_sverige. It is important to note that "kommer" could also be translated as "coming" or "will".

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